CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Part 6 - Governance, Network Security and Standards

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About This Report

This is an experimental, AI-driven research project from SRL. SRL is independent, with no outside funding and no sponsors. It uses several AI models from competing labs, running on different platforms. One model gathers the current claims on a topic, a different one checks each claim against its source, and disagreements are kept, not smoothed over. The aim is an even-handed account that no outside party has shaped. AI makes mistakes, and so does the system built around it. We find and fix some in every cycle, so the methods keep changing and the content should improve over time. Updates come at least quarterly, sooner if something major happens.

This part covers the Forum's machinery rather than its certificate rules. It is new in this edition. The September edition listed these areas as configured but not yet researched, and they now carry enough record to report.

Section 1 covers the Network Security Working Group, whose only live ballot finally has a result. Section 2 covers how the Forum governs itself, including the officers who take over on 1 December. Section 3 covers the IETF standards the guidelines cite, several of which moved closer to publication in October. Section 4 covers the audit regimes that check whether certificate authorities follow the rules.

1. Network Security Working Group

This group writes the Network and Certificate System Security Requirements, which govern how a certificate authority protects the systems that issue certificates rather than the certificates themselves.

Recent Developments

The group's restructuring ballot has passed after a long silence. NS-010 version 2 restructures the requirements sections, removes expired effective dates and updates a NIST reference [1]. Its vote ran from 10 August to 17 August 2026 [2]. No result followed, and on 9 September a participant asked on the list whether the chairs had forgotten to announce one [2].

The result was posted on 14 October [1]. The ballot passed with all sixteen voting certificate issuers and all three voting certificate consumers in favour, and no abstentions [1]. The consumers were Apple, Microsoft and Mozilla [1].

The ballot's text settles a question that earlier accounts left open. One account described an August ballot adding a section on infrastructure inventory, which seemed not to match NS-010's stated purpose. The draft shows they are the same ballot. NS-010 adds a new Section 1 for the certificate authority's infrastructure inventory and renumbers the sections after it [3].

The draft also replaces phased vulnerability management language, which expired on 15 April 2026, with a single requirement covering all certificate systems, support systems and network boundary controls [3]. Its NIST reference moves to Revision 4 of SP 800-63B [3].

Current State

NS-010 version 2 is adopted and in its intellectual property review, which runs from 14 October to 13 November 2026 [4]. It cannot publish as a new version before that review ends. Its pull request in the group's repository remains open and unmerged [3].

The published requirements are still version 2.0.5, from Ballot NS-008 in July 2025 [5]. The group's other draft, NS-009, would permit log storage systems in environments controlled by third parties [6]. It has not changed since May 2026 and has no ballot stage [6].

Unresolved Conflicts

The Forum's own ballots page still lists NS-010 version 2 as in its voting period [7]. The list posts show the vote closed in August and the result came in October [1]. The list is the record here, and the page lags it. An update to the page, or the ballot's publication in November, would close the gap.

2. Forum Governance

The Forum runs on bylaws, an intellectual property policy and elected officers, and changes to any of them move by Forum-level ballot or election rather than by working group.

Recent Developments

The Forum has chosen a new set of officers in two rounds. A special election for chairs ran from 14 September to 21 September and drew 21 ballots, with results posted on 23 September [8]. Dimitris Zacharopoulos was elected Forum chair, and three working group chairs were unopposed [8].

The network security chair race was tied between David Kluge and Aaron Poulsen [8]. On 24 September it was reported that the two candidates had agreed that Aaron Poulsen would take the chair [8].

The vice-chairs followed. Because no race was contested, the vice-chair ballot ran as a confirmation, from 6 October to 13 October, with no discussion period [9]. Nineteen ballots were received, and the results were posted on 15 October [9].

The confirmed vice-chairs are Karolina Ruszczynska of Certum for the Forum, and Tobias Josefowitz of Opera for the server certificate group [9]. Scott Rea of eMudhra takes S/MIME, Dean Coclin of DigiCert code signing, David Kluge of Google network security, and Ben Wilson of Mozilla the definitions group [9].

A corrected slate of chairs was posted the same day [9]. Stephen Davidson of DigiCert takes the server certificate group and Rebecca Kelley of DigiCert the S/MIME group [9]. Martijn Katerbarg of Sectigo takes code signing, Aaron Poulsen of SSL.com network security, and Polina Glazyrina of Sectigo the definitions group [9].

A proposal for a new working group is also under discussion. A charter for a client authentication working group was discussed on the public list from 22 September to 24 September, with emerging consensus to proceed [10]. Its scope was clarified as mutual TLS for people, not email [10]. Part 4 covers the root program policy that moves client authentication out of server certificates.

Current State

All the new officers take office on 1 December 2026 [9]. DigiCert will hold two chairs and one vice-chair, and Sectigo two chairs [9]. Google, Mozilla and Opera each hold one vice-chair seat and no chair [9].

The intellectual property policy in force is version 1.4, effective since 1 June 2026 [11]. Ballot FORUM-037 adopted it, and it is the newest Forum-level ballot to pass [12]. No Forum-level ballot is in any stage now, and the client authentication charter has no ballot, number or timeline [12] [10].

Parts of the record are missing. The minutes of the September face-to-face meeting, F2F 68, are not posted, and the server certificate group’s 8 October agenda recorded them as not yet distributed [13] [14]. The minutes of the 8 October Forum plenary are not posted either [13]. The same agenda recorded no membership applications [14].

One public question has drawn no answer. On 29 September a participant asked what “promptly” means in the subscriber obligations of the Baseline Requirements, given that the same document sets hard deadlines elsewhere [15]. No reply was visible by 4 October [15].

3. Referenced Standards

The guidelines cite IETF standards by number, so a draft becoming an RFC changes what a ballot can reference and when a requirement can be written.

Recent Developments

The composite signature draft is close to publication. It defines how ML-DSA is paired with a conventional signature in one X.509 certificate, and the S/MIME group’s composite ballot depends on it, as Part 3 records. It reached final review at the RFC Production Center on 14 October [16]. That is the last stage before the authors’ sign-off. As of 18 October it had no RFC number [17].

Its companion for key encapsulation moved too. The IESG approved the composite key encapsulation draft on 12 October, and it entered the RFC Editor queue [18]. The profile that applies composite key encapsulation to signed messages joined the queue on 15 October [19].

The two TLS drafts that put ML-KEM and ML-DSA directly into the protocol had been on hold since 24 September [20]. The hold was lifted on 5 October, and both have waited for an editor since 12 October [20] [21]. The record does not give a reason for the hold [20].

The ACME draft on account-bound domain labels went backward. Its area director began evaluation on 11 October and asked for a revised draft on 14 October [22]. No revision has been posted [22].

The Merkle Tree Certificates draft, the basis of the separate post-quantum trust path Chrome and Apple are designing, reached revision 07 on 7 October [23]. Chrome now requires new cosigner requests in its testing program to follow that revision [24]. The LAMPS working group posted new revisions of its two attestation drafts on 17 October [19].

Current State

No RFC on certificates, ACME, CAA or transparency appeared in October up to 15 October [25]. None from the LAMPS, TLS or ACME groups followed by 18 October [26]. RFC 5280, the core certificate profile, has had no erratum reported in 2026, and its newest is from September 2025 [27]. The CAA standards remain RFCs 8657, 8659 and 9495 [28].

The newest change to a standard the guidelines cite came before September. RFC 9919 defines a lightweight status protocol profile for high-volume environments and was published in July 2026 [29]. The ACME persistent DNS draft has stayed at revision 02 since 20 September [30].

4. Audit Regimes

A certificate authority proves compliance through an annual audit against WebTrust or ETSI criteria, and the root programs read those audits before granting or keeping trust.

Recent Developments

Two clusters of audit-related compliance bugs opened in mid-October. On 15 October D-Trust opened two bugs for findings in its 2026 ETSI audit, one on vulnerability management and one on the documentation of backup recovery tests [31]. Both remain unconfirmed [32].

On 16 October one member of the public filed four bugs about late audit statements [32]. Each says an authority delivered its statement between 108 and 144 days after the period ended, without the required explanation [32]. The authorities named are ITI Brazil, MULTICERT, Consorci AOC and Entrust [32]. All four are unconfirmed, and Part 4 covers them with the rest of the incident record [32].

The Baseline Requirements set the yardstick. Audit reports must be public no later than three months after the audit period ends [33].

Current State

The audit standards themselves did not change. ETSI EN 319 411-1 remains at version 1.5.1 from April 2025, with no newer edition [34]. EN 319 401 remains at version 3.2.1 from January 2026, and EN 319 411-2 at version 2.6.1 from June 2025 [35] [36].

On the WebTrust side, the criteria page lists version 2.2.2 as the base criteria for certificate authorities [37]. The European conformity assessment bodies’ council held its annual meeting in Tallinn on 17 September, and has posted nothing else in 2026 [38]. No root program changed its audit requirements between 2 October and 15 October [39].

Unresolved Conflicts

Two accounts disagree on the current WebTrust network security criteria. One says version 2.0.5 was released on 31 October 2025, effective for periods from 1 November 2025 and based on the Forum's requirements version 2.0.5 [40]. Later reads found version 1.7 still listed as current, effective for periods from April 2024 [41]. The criteria page itself refused a direct read. A successful read of that page would settle it.

The WebTrust applicability matrix, updated on 1 August 2026, lists TLS baseline versions 2.2.5 and 2.10 [42]. Read as Forum version numbers, neither matches the published sequence. It is not clear from the record whether they are the Forum's numbers or WebTrust's own. A direct read of the matrix would settle it.

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